

**On the Religious
in
its Unity with the Human**

A Positive Supplement to
“The Problem of Faith and Knowledge”

Om det Religiøse i dets Enhed med det Humane

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[Introduction]

The present work, whose publication has been delayed by circumstances independent of the author's will, attaches itself most closely to the historical-critical treatise: *Problemet om Tro og Viden*, in which reference is made to it in several places, and reproduces, like that treatise, in all essentials unchanged, the content of a university lecture course. It forms the positive supplement to that treatise, whose result, from the nature of the case, had essentially to be negative; and taking its starting point from this negative, it seeks, presupposing the developments by which that result was established, the definitive determination of faith's relation to knowledge.

The result, of a negative kind, to which all the developments given in the earlier work (in the "preliminary determinations of concepts", in the critique of theology's standpoint and of the attempt to bring about a reconciliation by a distinction of principle) have led, may be summed up in the following points:

1. Between faith in the sense of positive religion, i.e. faith as "faith in revelation", and knowledge there arises — whether the standpoint be taken in the positively religious or in science — in virtue of their different content and their different source, an unabolishable incongruence, an irreconcilable opposition.
2. It therefore becomes impossible that faith (in the sense indicated) and knowledge should be united without discord in the same consciousness, should preserve their validity for the same personality.

This negative result now converts itself immediately into a positive one differing from it only formally. If the opposites are irreconcilable in consciousness, then it becomes a necessity that a *choice* be made between these opposites, of which one must be the expression of the human spirit's highest energy, must enclose within itself the goal of its highest striving.

This choice, whose necessity under that presupposition is not to be evaded, is then, with respect to its character, to be formally determined thus: that in accordance with the

demand which lies in the unity of the human being and of human self-consciousness, it must be such a choice as one in which the spirit's fundamental activities are in harmony within themselves and with one another, in which therefore the being, undivided and unmutated, is in unity with itself in its cognising and its willing.

When this determination is taken as the norm, it becomes clear what direction the choice can and must take, what can and must become the object of the choice.

For from the developments given in the earlier work it emerges that faith, as faith in the sense of the positive religions, *cannot* be chosen if the demand set up above is to be fulfilled. That it cannot be so chosen lies partly in its relation to the practical, partly in its relation to the theoretical. It cannot be chosen because, in the practical respect, it cannot become the forming principle for the wholeness of an ethical human life, cannot form human nature. For on the standpoint of positive religion the source of the ethical demand becomes the supranatural, transcendent subject of revelation, distinguished from the human being, whose will is absolute arbitrariness; and the demands of this will cannot therefore be congruent with the essential demand of the human spirit. And when positive religion has been clarified into the highest form of a religion of spirit, then its "ethical" demand requires the denial of the natural, that is, of something fundamental in the human being, of something that *must* assert itself in its essentiality. — If we look to the theoretical, then faith cannot be chosen because it cannot round itself off into a totality, because, while it cannot make itself independent of knowledge, it cannot take up into itself what is essential in knowledge, cannot see through and explain knowledge^{*)}. Knowledge must then, as an essential determination in human nature, inevitably assert itself as justified over against faith, and bring discord into the consciousness that was to be filled by faith. A relation of subordination on knowledge's part is excluded by the kind of the opposition and by the essence of knowledge. When faith is chosen, therefore, the being's harmony and its inner reconciliation cannot be attained.

But when the demanded goal cannot be attained through the choice of faith, then there shows itself, through what was developed in the previous work, a possibility that it can be attained through a choice of knowledge. For in that knowledge is chosen, that is chosen which, by being an expression of the universality of the human being, has the capacity to unfold itself as a totality resting in itself with an inner infinity. In that knowledge is chosen, that is chosen in which the being in its unity becomes manifest to itself, that which in the indivisible human spirit holds the ideal principate, and which therefore can become the norm for a true ethical *wholeness of life*. In that knowledge

^{*)}Cf. Problemet om Tro og Viden, pp. 195; 210 f.

is chosen, there is finally chosen that which, as enclosing the cognition of the spirit's *whole* life and development of life, can see through the essence of the finite forms of religion and comprehend them in their springing from human nature in its unfolding, and therefore does not retain a disturbing barrier of consciousness within them; and which therefore also, in separating out within the historical forms of religion the transient and finite from the abiding and essential, can stand in harmony with and take up into itself this essential element, which is precisely the religious according to its true and eternal significance.

How now, from this standpoint of the necessity of a choice, and of a choice so determined, a *reconciling* solution of the problem of the relation of faith and knowledge becomes possible; how the right and validity of knowledge can be asserted without faith being violated in its truth, without the religious that is demanded by a need of the human spirit being denied — this it will be the task of the developments that follow to make clear. Their course is determined by the nature of the task. *First* it will be necessary to establish that there is present, conditioned by the unity of essence, a relation of unity between true cognition and true action, ethical action. *Thereafter* it shall be shown that the essential marks of the religious in its true and eternal sense — faith and devotion — are inseparable from true cognition and true action, and that these are therefore in harmony with the religious and bear it within themselves, so that human life, according to its harmonious unity with itself in the totality of its fundamental functions, can show itself as penetrated by the religious. And *finally* the possibility shall be shown that out of philosophy's concepts of the concretely determined Absolute — the highest determination of knowledge — and of the human being in its relation to the principle and to real existence, there can be developed a view of life that can satisfy ethically and religiously, and that there can be attained those essential determinations of the ethical and religious relation of which it has been asserted that they can be derived only from a principle of will and of faith absolutely heterogeneous with the principle of knowledge. Here, then, the central ethical-religious problems — the problems of the freedom of the will, of the possibility and actuality of ethical evil, and of reconciliation and restitution — will come up for discussion.

In connection with these developments there will at the same time be made clear the relation of the view of life indicated to those conceptions which offer real or apparent points of contact with it, and the critique of them given, partly directly, partly indirectly.

I.

On the Relation of Unity between True Cognition and True Action.

The fundamental relation between cognition and will, as primitive forms of expression of the human being, has been indicated in the earlier work (pp. 134 ff.), and to the determinations there given I may at this place refer back. The conception there asserted was this: that the human being, whose indivisible unity is posited by the concept of subjectivity and impresses itself in the unity of self-consciousness, is according to its fundamental concept a selfhood-energy, and that this determination of the selfhood-energy is the pervading universal which gives itself its peculiar forms of activity in cognition and will. In these peculiar forms of expression, then, the universal determinateness of the being reveals itself; they become primitive functions of the selfhood-energy; and while their originality encloses their peculiarity and their self-validity, their relation to the universal determination of the selfhood-energy — the determination inherent in the particular — encloses this: that they are governed by the unity of the being, that they reflect one another's formal determinatenesses, and that the essential energy therefore preserves its unity in the twofold form of appearance. By the *equal* relation in which cognition and will have been shown to stand to the determination of the energy, that confusion of concepts is removed which, through an arbitrary and unclear extension of the concept *drive*, identifies drive with the energy and thereby procures for the will an illusory precedence in the human being, without being able, then, to explain the origin of cognition, or of consciousness generally; without being able to remove the confusion that "the drive" is itself to posit what the drive, in the *proper* sense of the word, strives to hold fast *or* to remove; and without being able to account for the fact that the first expression of the selfhood-energy, as unconscious organic forming, continues *after* the will has been actualised, and continues *independently* of the will. Through the critique of this one-sided and unclear conception the primitivity both of cognition and of will has been

asserted; and when the question of the ideal principate was raised, this was assigned to cognition in virtue of its relation to that fundamental determination in the human being, *essential universality*, by which the human being categorically distinguishes itself from the other stages of the development of life^{*)}. This ideal principate of cognition reveals itself also in *consciousness's* relation to the particular functions of spirit. As functions of the human selfhood-energy they are *accompanied by consciousness*, and are precisely thereby functions *of spirit*; but consciousness stands according to its concept in another relation to cognition and thought than, for example, to the will; it becomes the *abstract, formal*, expression of cognition, that which can be unfolded into an *appropriating cognition*, into *comprehending* thinking, into the transparency of spirit to itself in its content; and the fact that it enters into relation to the different functions of spirit, in becoming the form of their being-for-the-self, points precisely to the ideal principate of cognition, and to the possibility of a transparency of the self to itself through cognition in the self's various peculiar forms of expression^{**)}. When this fundamental point — the being's undivided unity in cognition and will, and the ideal principate of cognition — has already been won as a result in the earlier work, then at this place the *relative* opposition is to be more closely elucidated which must come forward in virtue of the peculiarity of the fundamental functions and in virtue of the conditions of the development of spirit, but through which, in virtue of the fundamental relation, harmony — the unity grounded in essence — must actualise itself as governing the opposition.

The relative opposition in which cognition and will come forward in their independence is to be apprehended first as an opposition *of concept*, and thereafter as an opposition *of facticity*.

The opposition of concept between the two primitive functions has already been indicated in "Problemet om Tro og Viden" (pp. 135 f.). It showed itself as coming forward immediately in the difference of formal determinateness; but the difference of form was seen not to constitute an abstract opposition, since the determinations which expressed it pointed to one another and developed out of one another, so that the fundamental functions reflected one another's formal determinatenesses. Thereby it became possible

^{*)}Cf. Problemet om Tro og Viden, p. 137; Et Svar til Prof. Nielsen, pp. 12 f.

^{**)}With respect to the charge which a critic has brought against me of confounding what is essentially different, I remark only — what every thoughtful reader of the earlier work will surely have seen — that I do not identify the *immediate forms of consciousness* with unfolded *scientific cognition*, but maintain only that what comes forward in those forms of immediacy is partly such as can be unfolded in clear cognition, and partly a *resulting* immediate, and more precisely such a one as has resulted from a preceding *cognition*. Just as little do I confound the *subjective* with the *objective*; rather I maintain that the former, as an expression of the subject's *being*, has the same transparency for cognition, i.e. for a *theoretical* cognition, as has that immediate.

that beneath the difference of form the *essential* unity of the content can be preserved: a unity which is required by the fact that the same undivided being gives both forms their content. When thus, in the ethical resolution, the cognition of duty is converted into a willing of duty — when therefore that which as an object of cognition has the form of possibility is posited in the form of actuality in the I — then this *determinate* content is in both forms *essentially* unchanged, and must be so already for this reason, that otherwise the fulfilment of duty in the action would *not* be a fulfilment of this determinate thing cognised as duty; and in the preceding cognition the universal determination of possibility is so punctualised in relation to the existing subject, and the object of cognition so brought into relation to the cognising *being*, so seen as an essential determination which is required to be posited as a determination of reality, that the conversion into a content of will cannot abolish the essential unity of the content.

That the difference between cognition and will does not transform itself into an *abstract* opposition shows itself also indirectly when we elucidate the attempt to assert such an opposition through the opposition between the “theoretical” and the “practical consciousness”, between “theoretical” and “practical cognition” (thinking).

With respect to this theory we touch only upon what we have shown elsewhere: the lack of clarity in the application of the categories of which it makes itself guilty, in that the concepts consciousness, cognition and thinking are used indiscriminately without clear delimitation, and cognition, which relates itself to action, is confounded with the act of will itself, the resolution of the will. Disregarding this confused application of the concepts, and distinguishing what has been called practical cognition from the immediate “practical consciousness” — which is partly a consciousness of the subject’s state in the practical respect, of the subject’s resolution of will and of the motive, the factually moving, and partly a consciousness of the ethically a priori, of the practical demand — we investigate how the sought opposition between a theoretical and a practical cognition is to be determined.

It will then be immediately evident here that there cannot be two essentially distinct kinds of cognition, two absolutely heterogeneous forms of cognition, since in that case the determination of cognition would transform itself into a purely contentless name and in its duality could not be the property of the same cognising being. An opposition which springs from the ground of the same being must preserve within itself the essential unity. And therefore it is to be held fast that cognition, *as* cognition, in every form and in every application, must preserve its essential determinateness. The opposition between a “theoretical” and a “practical” cognition then becomes a merely relative opposition

between a cognition which is determined solely by the laws of thought and which has theoretical insight as its result, and a cognition which is determined also by motives of will (laws of will) and which has action, resolution, as its result.

The designation of practical cognition as determined by motives of will points partly to this cognition's presuppositions and starting points (premisses), partly to its being affected by the will in the course of its advance. Its starting points are practical incitements: partly promptings of drive, partly effects of an ethical *a priori* (grounds of conscience). From these starting points, which stand as something given, "practical" cognition then advances in the same way as the theoretical, which draws consequences from its premisses, partly from unresolved ones and partly from transparent ones. — Cognition's being affected in the course of its advance may proceed from a more clearly or a more obscurely conscious will, which either supplements incomplete premisses, or corrects one-sided theories, or hinders true cognition. In the first case the will supplies a starting point which, in order to be used, must not stand in conflict with what is theoretically cognised. The relation here forms an analogy to that in which, in theoretical reasoning, an unproved current opinion (a prejudice) is used. In the second case the will inserts a corrective which cognition acknowledges as its own, and which forms the starting point for a new inference. Here too the theoretical domain offers perfectly corresponding analogies (cf. *Problemet om Tro og Viden*, pp. 144 f.). — In the last case the relation is more complicated. During cognition's advance the will works partly by bringing forward instances that can prevent a conclusion, and partly by spacing out the unfolding of the premisses from the conclusion, the resolution, whereby the clarity of cognition can be obscured, and contradicting instances, specious grounds and pretexts can take on the appearance of validity. To this hindering there is formed, in the theoretical domain, the analogy of the working of prejudices upon cognition.

The *result* of "practical cognition" is partly the acceptance of a doctrine which relates itself to the subject's action, to its practical life, and partly an inference in the direction of action, which is converted into a resolution. If the result is the acceptance of a doctrine, then this acceptance comes forward as an inference which proceeds with necessity from its premisses; but among these premisses there may be found, according to what has been developed above, such as have been inserted by the will. If the result is resolution, as resolution to the determinate action, then the preceding act of cognition — to which the resolution in the proper sense always points back — is, like the cognition upon which the acceptance of the practical doctrine depended, and like the cognition which drew consequences from practical premisses, in its form not essentially different from

the theoretical; but this would be impossible if an absolute heterogeneity separated “practical” and “theoretical” cognition from one another. For cognition is only what it is by its form; but by form is then of course understood something other and more than the empty syllogistic form applied *externally* to an arbitrary content.

The result with respect to the cognition which relates itself to the practical is therefore this: that in virtue of its form and in virtue of its relation to the universal concept of cognition, and likewise in virtue of the relation of the practical — of the starting points and of the result — to the human *being*, it must be essentially one with the cognition designated as theoretical. All cognition is *as* cognition theoretical. That cognition can be applied in a practical direction, and in this application be affected by the will, proves nothing for an essentially distinct practical cognition; for a unity of the will with cognition comes forward *everywhere*, its reciprocal action with cognition becomes manifest in the domain of indisputably theoretical cognition as well, and theoretical cognition can *as such* become an object of the will. That the relation is of this kind will become still more evident when the *marks of character* are examined by which the alleged abstract opposition between theoretical and practical cognition is *described*: they will all show themselves as leading back from the relative difference to the essential unity.

When the opposition is first characterised thus, that the *theoretical* consciousness (cognition) is *impersonal* and the *practical* *personal*, then this opposition, as an abstract and exclusive opposition, shows itself untenable already for this reason: that theoretical cognition, as the expression of the unity of that being whose fundamental determination is personality, must not merely be an expression of personality in general, but must have for its final goal a cognition of personality in its connection with the whole of existence and in its subordination under the principle of existence. In this cognition of the personal self, the cognition of objective real existence — of that world of corporeality to which personality stands in relation through its side of reality and its conditions of reality — will then also show itself as having “personal” significance. That determination of theoretical cognition as impersonal encloses the consequence that *theoretical cognition, although a primitive expression of the self, cannot become self-cognition*, inasmuch as it finds its limit in the very self which is the source of this cognition. If, in order to maintain the assertion of theoretical cognition’s impersonal character, one were to lay the emphasis on this, that the cognition of the self too, as theoretical cognition, must remain in the form of the universal, and that therefore the personal self can through it be cognised only in an impersonal manner — then it would have to be urged against this

that the universal in such cognition is not held fast in the original form of abstraction, but is constantly more and more punctualised towards concretion, so that what remains “impersonal” in theoretical cognition would designate only what remains relative in the punctualisation of the universal; and this relative element is moreover such as is not merely abiding in theoretical cognition, but is and must be so in the resolutions of the will as well, precisely because these are conscious and are expressions of spirit, and as such are raised above that form of singularity which belongs to natural existence and to natural determination by drive.

The object of impersonal, theoretical cognition is determined as the *objectively valid*, that of personal, practical cognition as the *subjectively valid*, and an abstract opposition is made between the objectively universally valid and the subjectively universally valid. When, however, that self-contradicting limit upon theoretical cognition is removed, it shows itself to comprehend also that which, as a “subjectively valid”, was set in opposition to the objectively valid, and to comprehend not merely what, in virtue of its connection with cognised human nature, has validity in its universality for all subjects, but also what, as determined in its concretion by co-operating universal grounds, has validity for this determinate subject.

Only in virtue of this relation can there be any talk of a “subjectively universally valid”, whereas the abstract opposition between the subjective and the objective must lead to letting *individual* subjectivity as such determine the valid as it *wills* to determine it, and so to letting the subjective grounds become one with individually accidental grounds, promptings of drive and the like — to letting “grounds of will” become such as an arbitrary will makes into grounds.

If the opposition between the two kinds of cognition is then determined thus, that theoretical cognition is moved by *necessity* while practical cognition “*is grounded in freedom*” — the former, as lost in the universal, being compellingly determined by incontrovertible grounds of knowledge, the latter, as conditioned by regard for the self, resting on grounds of conscience — then this opposition too shows itself to be dialectical. Theoretical cognition is governed by necessity where the presuppositions of the inference are fully transparent, where the proof acquires stringency through clear and complete premisses. But just as fully is “practical cognition” determined with necessity where these conditions are present, where the presuppositions are given clear and complete. What produces the appearance of an abstract opposition is *the difference in concretion* between the object of practical cognition and certain spheres of the theoretical. In the domain of the concretely ethical a seemingly unabolishable

difference may persist, precisely on account of the incompleteness of the premisses, in the same way as within the theoretical, in the more concrete domains. The difference can maintain itself because the manifold presuppositions are not clarified and are therefore partially supplemented in an individual manner. Thus, under the same presuppositions, the necessity is the same. And the necessity which determines theoretical cognition is, when the cognition is *comprehending* and as such *appropriating*, an expression of *the lawfulness of the cognising being itself*, and thus converts itself into *freedom*. In the form of unfree necessity theoretical cognition comes forward only where what is given in sensation is determinative in its foreignness. But to this stage there corresponds that stage in the development of practical “cognition” where the regard for the self which determines it is regard for something obscurely drive-like, by which the will is brought under natural necessity. Only as the expression of something essential has the subject’s need, which determines that “cognition”, any warrant; but as an expression of the being this need bears at once the stamp of true necessity and of freedom, while the so-called “freedom” of determination by drive is unfree necessity, just as the necessity of sensation is. In theoretical and in practical cognition alike, therefore, *both the* determinations come forward which were to constitute the sharp opposition; the real relation becomes obscure only through this, that the individual who acts “arbitrarily” does not become conscious of being, precisely in this action, unfree.

When finally the opposition is determined in this way, that theoretical cognition is to be *disinterested*, *contemplative*, *without responsibility*, while the practical is *interested*, moved by *fear and hope*, an object of *responsibility* – then this opposition stands as the previous ones do. Theoretical consciousness is *disinterested* when “interested” is taken in the sense of egoism; it is on the contrary interested in the highest degree when interest is taken in the sense of a striving towards an essential end, and this end for theoretical cognition is precisely the self’s clarity about itself, its being for itself as self-conscious according to its total concretion. That spirit theoretically finds rest in any result whatever to which the consequences of the presuppositions lead is correct only in so far as spirit can halt momentarily at that result; but in the untrue or only half-true result there is always a stimulus which again awakens cognition’s interest for a new investigation and again drives it forward, precisely because the untrue result cannot come into accord with, or comprehend, that totality of cognition which cognition according to its essence must strive to work out^{*)}.

Theoretical cognition is to be *contemplative*, absorbed in the grounding of the ob-

^{*)}Theoretical cognition’s interest in its result comes strikingly forward in its supplementing of the incomplete premisses of the inductive inference.

jective; but it is so only in the sense limited by the earlier determinations. From the contemplative, self-forgetting absorption in the universal and objective it seeks back to the punctual and to that self-cognition towards which an irresistible inner need drives it; and in striving towards its goal there is, in cognition's *struggle* for the appropriation of actuality, in the *true* cognition's struggle against the untrue, something corresponding to the will's conflict with existence, to its struggle for its realisation, to the good will's struggle against evil.

Theoretical cognition is finally to be *without personal responsibility*, the practical accompanied by the consciousness of such. This opposition too is untenable in the form in which it is set up. That with respect to the consciousness of responsibility there is a difference between the *act of will* and the activity of thought, when regard is had only to this, that the former intervenes determiningly in reality while the latter does not, at any rate not in a conscious manner, goes without saying. But the activity of cognition does not therefore fall outside responsibility. The act of cognition, which is subject to *the norm of the idea of truth*, has in that norm an "ought", in relation to which there is a consciousness of responsibility. When responsibility in general points to this, that what the individual is responsible for is the individual's own deed, that it proceeds from the individual's being, and that it stands in relation to a higher, more comprehensive law, then responsibility becomes common to what proceeds from the activity of cognition and from that of the will; and it must become so all the more, since the normal activity of cognition is, as will appear in what follows, the condition of the normal activity of the will. Cognition's connection with responsibility is therefore not to be apprehended merely thus, that the will's relation to cognition can bring cognition under responsibility, but thus, that cognition *in and for itself*, by its relation to the individual's being and to the higher law of truth, comes under it.

Through the consideration of the marks of character by which an abstract opposition between "theoretical" and "practical cognition" (consciousness), and thereby between cognition and will, was to be maintained, we are thus led to the *same result* as above: that the *abstract opposition* yields its place to an *essential unity* which *governs the relative difference*, and *must* do so, on account of the relation of the primitive expressions of the being to the unity of the being. This result will now receive a new confirmation when we consider the *opposition of facticity* between cognition and will, the opposition into which they can enter towards one another in the course of the individual development of the life of spirit.

A *factual* opposition comes forward at the imperfect stages of development of cogni-

tion and will: partly under the form of a one-sided development of cognition or of will; partly under the form of an indifference of the will towards, or an independence of it from, cognition; partly under the form of the act of will's opposition to cognition.

The *first* of these forms of divergence finds its explanation^{*)} in the sporadic element which comes forward, and must come forward, at the subordinate stages of development, but which at the highest stage of development — the stage at which cognition and will are determined by reason in their concrete content — must be joined together in unity and harmony. And unity is not merely the goal of the development: in the course of the diverging development there is a pointer towards it in this, that the one-sided development of cognition is defective not merely with respect to will but also with respect to cognition itself, just as the one-sided development of will is defective not merely with respect to cognition but with respect to will as well — so that the belonging-together and reciprocal conditioning of what has been separated becomes plain. Cognition developed one-sidedly, and not united with a development and firmness of will in the personality, will always show itself to be an abstract and uncarried-through cognition; a will developed one-sidedly, and not united with the richness and clarity of cognition, will show itself to be a will not yet purified through, and therefore not liberated from the instinctive, the fanatical and the violent, and thereby from the egoistic.

In the *second* form of the difference an effect of the sporadic likewise^{**)} makes itself felt, as where one acts from a mere prompting of drive or in blind passion; or else the resolution has only an incomplete cognition for its presupposition, and one acts from the immediacy of the concentrated personality. With respect to this last case there has been shown, in the earlier work (p. 144), the form under which, in such a resolution, a preceding cognition that has “gone back into immediate being in spirit” is at work^{*)}. The relation between the resolution and the incomplete presupposition of cognition has its exact parallel within the theoretical, in the inference which, with an incomplete empirical foundation — an experience not exhausted — for its presupposition, states the universal not hypothetically but categorically.

In the *third* form of divergence there makes itself felt partly^{**)} a working of the ethically a priori in the will's determining of itself in opposition to one-sided theory, and partly a counter-working of the will against the true, through an affecting of cognition

^{*)}Cf. *Problemet om Tro og Viden*, pp. 136 f.

^{**)}The same work, pp. 142 ff.

^{*)}A more thorough psychological observation will show that the concept of a determinateness of the will proceeding from a cognition that has gone back into immediate being — cognition taken in the widest sense of the concept — finds application also in the will's first expressions in the child, since the “pronouncedness” of these expressions follows step by step the pronouncedness of the life of representation.

^{**)}*Problemet om Tro og Viden*, p. 144.

and through a hindering of cognition's realisation. With respect to the activity which the ethically a priori exercises in consciousness, "Problemet om Tro og Viden", p. 145, has pointed to the parallel with the working which the a priori exercises within the theoretical, and it has been established that the *ethically* a priori, as an *essence*-determination and as an expression of the *undivided* being for which *knowledge* too is an expression, must also be a *knowledge*-determination and be transparent to cognition, so that its working is a working of that which finds its place within knowledge and enters into the system of knowledge's fundamental concepts. — As regards the will's conflict with what is cognised as true, this will show itself to take place only in relation to an *imperfect* cognition, and therefore to be confined to those stages of development at which the power of the sporadic is unconquered. A sharper psychological and ethical observation will confirm that clear, *concrete* cognition is never powerless against the will, that it is impossible to act against such an *actual* cognising. Could the will withstand what was in this way cognised as the *being's* determination, as the being's demand, then it would act merely in virtue of the essenceless, or the being would have to be split into two heterogeneous parts; but the former is self-contradictory, and such a split in the being, according to which the will would be something irrational and cognition something rational, is an empty representation, which becomes no less empty if, instead of a split, a "defectiveness" in the being is spoken of by way of postulate. In such cases as seem to speak for the will's unconditional power to withstand cognition, cognition will partly show itself to be incomplete in such a way that in its abstraction it as it were gives room for the conflicting action; and partly it will appear that cognition, as not yet fully unfolded, is by an act of will — more clearly or more obscurely conscious — which affects the direction of thought, brought outside the focus of consciousness, moved off into a distance of time for consciousness, and thereby obscured and hindered, so that it can be paralysed by a conflicting illusory cognition, an excuse, a pretext; and only through such a spacing-out does the conflicting action become possible. The clear cognition of what is unethical in an action, of its opposition to a preceding better cognition, sets in only *after* the action. Here the *time*-determination acquires a decisive significance.

While thus the factual divergence which at the imperfect stages of development can take place between cognition and will does not show itself to be of such a kind as to abolish the inner unity, this inner unity — in which cognition and will stand as expressions of the same being — finds its impress in that parallelism between the universal stages of development of cognition and of will which comes forward in spite of the unlike development the two functions of spirit may have in the individual. Just as cognition

develops from its first form, sensation, through the involuntary formation of universal representations, to a conscious and progressive separating out of the universal in the concept, so the will develops from the first, immediate, single determinateness by drive, through a determinateness by involuntarily formed *practical universal representations* — produced by a spontaneously arising momentary and partial reflection, such as make themselves felt in an abiding inclination — to a determinateness by consciously formed principles, maxims, out of which the unity of a view of life may then proceed.

The harmony and unity to which there was a pointer even in the divergence itself then comes forward unveiled at that stage of development of cognition and will at which the human spirit has attained to clarity about itself according to its concrete essential determination. In that the human spirit here becomes conscious in cognition of the content of its being, it expresses this content of cognition in the determinateness of the will: the will makes that content of cognition, in which the being becomes manifest to *itself*, into *its own* content, realises the being in its own form, in the resolution; and it does so in virtue of the necessity lying in the unity of the individually-universal, ideally-real being, in virtue of that law of the being which lets the being manifest itself in its *total* formal determinateness, and therein manifest itself in harmony with itself^{*)}. In the resolution the will is determined by the necessity of the being; but inasmuch as this necessity is the necessity of its *own* being, the will is *self*-determining through freedom. In order that the being may realise itself in an act of will, in the proper sense of that concept, it must first have become manifest to itself in cognition; but the will's self-determining is maintained through that relation to the essence-*totality*.

If, after having elucidated the universal relation between the theoretical and the practical, we seek the closer determination of *cognition's true form* — of the form which is the goal of its development — then it is to be found from the fundamental relation of consciousness. In the relation given in the human spirit between self-consciousness and consciousness there lies the necessity of a striving to bring all content of consciousness under the unity of self-consciousness, to abolish the foreignness of the object of consciousness and to make it transparent for spirit in a comprehending cognising, in which the self has its ideal unfolding and its self-revelation, in that it ideally appropriates actuality. Only in such a comprehending cognising, in which the content of consciousness forms for spirit a unity answering to the unity of self-consciousness, is

^{*)}Cf. Problemet om Tro og Viden, p. 142.

that contradiction abolished which lies in the relation of consciousness: that the object is in my consciousness as a determination of *my* consciousness, and yet according to its content is something foreign to me; and only in such cognising is that contradiction likewise abolished, that spirit — which in self-consciousness relates itself to itself in an infinite manner and is in unity with itself — is at the same time foreign to itself through the foreign content which the self comprehends. But when such a leading back of the content of consciousness to transparent unity with self-consciousness is cognition's demand, determined by the fundamental psychological relation, then such a leading back and such a unity become possible only on condition of a cognition of the principle which is the principle of unity of the self and of existence; and cognition's true form then becomes a principle-determined unity of cognition, in which the self, in cognising itself as an organic member ordered into the totality governed by the principle, can cognise itself according to its concretion. Such a form of cognition, in its essence like that which philosophy according to its concept is to give, must — in virtue of its relation to the original demand of consciousness, in virtue of its universal principle, in virtue of the kind of thought it presupposes, in virtue of the consciousness it encloses of the essence and fundamental relation of thought, in virtue of its combining of the a priori and the empirical — claim for itself the place of cognition's τέλος.

If we seek *action's true* form, then this must be determined from the will's fundamental relation to the essence of the self-conscious spirit. Since man is a self-conscious being and as self-conscious is a willing being, that working which in the animal, as unconscious and unfree fulfilment of drive, is only a deed acquires the character of *action*, i.e. of a *conscious* working proceeding from *will*. More closely, the nature of action is to be determined thus: that it is not merely accompanied by the consciousness *that* one is acting, but is determined by the consciousness of *why* one is acting. Action as action, in the proper sense of the word, is directed towards a goal, an *end*, is guided by this, is a conscious working for the attainment of this end. Action's goal, the consciously willed end, may, seen from the standpoint of the objective, show itself as an immediate or as a mediate goal: as that which stands directly in relation to the will and is willed for its own sake, or as that which stands in relation to the will only through something else and is willed for the sake of something else, as a means to the attainment of the end. But when, with respect to the objective, we speak of a willing of it for its own sake, this is nevertheless to be understood only in comparison with the objective means, not so that the subject's relation to itself is excluded, or the agent's subjective interest in the objective forgotten. The subject of action relates itself, as subject, at every point to itself;

in determining the objective as an end, it determines it as *its* end, and relates itself *to itself* in the realisation of the end, wills *itself* in willing the objective. Through the relation to the objective we are therefore led back to the relation to the subject; and that we are led back to it lies in the very essence of subjectivity, in its fundamental determination: to be for itself in its other. The end of action becomes then everywhere the subject itself, and this holds also of the action through which the subject gives itself up to the higher; for through self-surrender the higher self-affirmation is won.

But when the determination given holds of *all* action, then within it falls the opposition between *true* and *untrue* action. Action's truth is determined by the truth of the will (of the will's determinateness); but the will's truth is determined by whether the willing subject, in willing *itself*, wills itself *according to its truth*, i.e. according to its *essential determination*, and more closely, according to its *full* essential determination. *True action* is therefore that in which the will makes the realisation of the being — of which the will is a primitive expression — into its end, in which the will therefore works as *essence-willing*.

In opposition to this true form of action, which we anticipatively designate as *ethical* action, the *untrue* form of action becomes — setting aside for the present the unethical action, whose essence will be determined later — the *not yet* ethical, imperfect action, which proceeds from the subject's willing of itself according to its particular determinateness of immediacy, according to its finitude and contingency, according to its phenomenal existence. Such a willing becomes a willing by the subject of itself according to its ungoverned side of sensibility — sensibility being taken here in the widest compass of the concept — as an unconsciously egoistic willing of enjoyment. In this form of action, and in the will from which it proceeds, there lies an inner contradiction which reveals its untruth. When the self, as sensibly determined, wills enjoyment, it wills *itself* through enjoyment, in that in enjoyment it wills its self-affirmation as sensible. But in willing enjoyment the self wills that which is *independent* of the self's willing and which according to its nature is *changeable* — that, therefore, which *cannot* be governed by the will and which in its incommensurability with the self's universal essence *cannot* be held fast by the will. And in willing itself in the ununified manifoldness and essenceless changeableness of enjoyment, the self wills itself in a determinateness — the determinateness of sensible externality — in which its unity is abolished; it wills itself, therefore, in that in which, while it seeks a self-affirmation, it *loses itself*; it wills itself as not-self. The inner contradiction is abolished only when the will — which as an expression of the being must according to its concept be essence-willing — becomes

a willing of that which in truth *can* be willed, because it is one with the essence of the willing subject: a willing of that in which the self affirms itself according to its unity and abiding essentiality, according to the infinity of its essence. To such a willing of itself there is, at the imperfect stages of development of the will, a pointer, as to the goal at which the will finds rest, in that the will realises what was obscurely striven for at those lower stages of development. The goal of will and action, which is determined by the self and in which the self relates itself to itself, must from the beginning be covertly determined from *the self's unity* — a determining which betrays itself through the working-forth of the universal — and as the self becomes clear to itself according to its essence, it must *consciously* and *freely* be determined from *the self's content-rich unity*, so that the self according to its *total* essential determinateness, according to its true universality and infinity, becomes the contradiction-free τέλος of will and action. But such a willing by the self of itself according to its truth, according to the infinity of its essence, is *ethical* willing.

For this ethical, essential willing a twofold determination has been indicated in what immediately precedes, and the two stand in the closest inner connection. The ethical is constituted in that the self wills itself *according to its essence*, and in that — this being the condition of the former — it draws itself out of its immediate being with that being's unfreedom, finitude and changeableness, and by *freedom* determines itself *as spirit* according to its *inner infinity*. At the stage which lies before the ethical, the self willed that which as finite is something vanishing and is independent of the will; it willed *itself*, therefore, in what is something vanishing and something foreign to the self, that is to say, it lost itself. As it becomes conscious of the transitoriness of what is willed and of the contradiction lying therein, the opposition comes forward between the transitory finite and the infinite and unconditioned; there shows itself a *choice*; and as the will, in despair of the finite, frees itself from the finite and chooses the infinite, the ethical breaks through. But the infinite is chosen precisely in that the self chooses itself according to its essence; for that means: according to the *determination of eternity* within it, according to its *eternal validity*. In this *resolution of choice*, which is a *self-acquiring of freedom*, the oppositions in the choice receive a new elucidation and a new determination: the determination of the *good* and the *evil* — concepts which first belong in the ethical domain; and in the ethical choice the good is chosen.

In choosing itself according to its essence and through the choice willing its essence, the self has therefore made a movement of *infinity*: its *immediate* being according to its determinateness by *nature* is converted into a being of *spirit* through *itself*, through its

freedom. In that the self, through that infinitising choice, chooses and wills itself, it wills itself *absolutely*, i.e. *as an absolute*; and *only itself*, i.e. *its own essence*, can the self will absolutely; but this willing is possible only in that it wills the *Absolute* in the self. *The self* which chooses itself by the absolute willing of the ethical resolution has a *twofold* significance: it is the *ideal, universal self*, the self's absolute essence, that is chosen; but the choosing self, which chooses that essence as *its own*, is the *individual self*, which in choosing that other self chooses itself in its individuality. This is to say: it *takes over* its own development, lying prior to the ethical choice; but in taking it over in the choice of the ideal self, it takes it over as that development shows itself in the ideal self's light. In other words: it passes the ethical judgement of *repentance* upon that development; it *transforms* itself in principle in the ethical resolution, in virtue of its fundamental essence. In this repentant choosing the self gathers itself together in its whole finite concretion; and while in the choice it as it were takes itself out of finitude, it is in the most absolute continuity with finitude and has itself as its task in its ethically chosen concrete actuality — an actuality which is to be worked through by, and penetrated with, the universal, so that the actual self is determined by the ideal self which it has within it, and expresses at one and the same time the individual and the universally human^{*)}.

For *ethical willing*, whose essence and task are thus determined, there now shows itself — both in its first constituting of itself and in its unfolding in action's concrete determinateness — *true cognition* as an essential and necessary *condition*.

For the immediate working of the ethically a priori, by which such a presupposition of cognition might seem to be replaced, shows itself insufficient. That the a priori has an activity which reveals itself in conscience is incontrovertible; but in order that this activity may be raised above a merely enveloped (implicit) presence in the form of the merely instinctive and drive-like, it presupposes a development of cognition, just as the logically a priori presupposes such a development in order to be freed from what hinders and obscures it. In that first working the ethically a priori works immediately together with promptings of drive, works itself under the form of a prompting of drive — for example under the form of sympathy, of natural love — but is not clarified into ethical freedom. Therefore the ethically a priori in its immediate working is insufficient as a regulative for action. In the immediate prompting, which is not yet clarified through by cognition, it remains constantly uncertain how far what prompts is something in truth a priori, and as such a true essential determination, or whether it is not something untrue, an expression of something unwarranted, something phenomenal and contingent. And since the a

^{*)}Cf. the developments in *Kierkegaard's Enten* — Eller, II.

priori as a priori has the stamp of the abstract, it becomes, when it is not unfolded into concretion by cognition, insufficient for the determination of the concrete action. When action is called for, the subject will come to seek the determinateness of the action outside the abstract norm, in its own unclarified, nature-determined immediacy, in which it is not conscious of itself according to its essence; and there will then arise a dividedness and doubleness in the will, since the universal and the particular, the norm and the concrete content of the action, cannot be willed as one. This contradictory doubleness can vanish only when the essential demand unfolds itself in concrete determinateness for cognition.

The diversity of what at different times, at the different stages of human development, has been held to be morally right confirms the insufficiency of the immediate prompting by the a priori. One need take as an example only the manner in which the feeling of reverence for the divine, or the immediate feeling of piety towards parents, has found its expression.

In virtue of the ethically a priori there may be an immediate consciousness of an ethical obligation, as an obligation towards something higher; but the clear consciousness of *that which obliges* is conditioned by true cognition, and likewise the *assured* consciousness of the concrete content of the obligation is conditioned by such cognition — by the concrete cognition of that which obliges and of the *essential determinateness* and *essential content* of the one obliged. Instinctively one may live in accordance with the moral, in that the objectively moral — custom and tradition — immediately determines the acting individual, who in a relation of piety subordinates itself to this objective as to a higher power in which it feels something akin to itself, and whose law it therefore follows, not as a foreign law. Instinctively the immediate consciousness may grasp the good, may act in the spirit of morality, in that it, unconsciously affected by the surrounding moral element of life, acknowledges something universal and ideal as the norm of action, gives up the egoistic, and in the particular action acts with the will of resignation, guided by its determinateness in principle. But custom and tradition, the surrounding moral atmosphere of life — whether they be the resultant of the immediate working of the a priori or of a preceding cognition which has as it were been deposited in immediate being — can be the secure norm only when they can again be freed, in living cognition, from the immediate form in which something contingent and foreign may cling to them. The clear, free, assuring consciousness of the moral and of the inner connection within it can be attained only through such a cognition as separates out the contingency of immediacy, and more determinately through that kind of cognition

by which what is cognised can acquire inner unity and necessity — therefore through the principle-determined cognition whose essence has been developed above. Such a cognition has, in its incompleteness — inseparable from the conditions of human development — and in its relative abstraction, the essential truth and the possibility of as it were growing out from its centre and filling out its forms without their being displaced. With such cognition for its presupposition the ethical will acquires its true form, precisely because the being is in that cognition clear to itself; and in its liberation from finite entanglement, from the obscurely drive-like which in itself is the changeable and which, even in its direction towards the good, knows no limit, the ethical will acquires that true resoluteness, firmness and purity which is conditioned by the being-for-cognition of what is willed. The subject's concrete cognition of its essence and of the true demand of that essence acquires here its decisive practical significance.

From what has been developed it becomes clear that cognition's significance for the ethical already comes forward where the ideal self is to be made *with consciousness* into the object of the will, where something *absolute* and *unconditioned* announces itself and is to be separated out from what veils and obscures it. But it comes forward still more clearly when the idea of the good is to be realised in the *concretion* of the moral will, to be worked out in the actuality of a wholeness of life — when, what becomes identical with this, the self's willing of itself according to its ideal essence is to attain the concrete form of actuality of the ethical action, the realisation of the human being through free human action, action in truth agreeing with itself and with its own essence. For only through the true and concrete cognition of the self's essence and of its fundamental relation does free action become in its determinateness action *determined by reason*, does the ethical unfold its rational content *clearly and unmixed*. Since the *ethically a priori* in its abstraction meets with something concretely given, with something *empirical*, then in this meeting — which is to lead to a determining of the latter by the former, to an unfolding of the abstract ethical consciousness of essence into an essential consciousness of actuality — only the true form of cognition, which acknowledges the *a priori* and realises its essential unity with the empirical — a cognition, therefore, of the kind determined above — can be guiding in the last instance. Only through it can the self's willing of its essence become a willing of the essence according to its complete concrete determinateness; only through it can the self in its acting truly “will one thing”). —

An expression of this significance of cognition for action is the fact that *ethics*, the scientific cognition of the ethical, must acquire its *essential* significance for that ethical.

^{*)}Cf. Section III (on the realisation of the ideal).

If *scientific* cognition is cognition's clearest and most complete unfolding, then what has been said of true cognition must find its immediate application to it.

Since ethical action is determined as action's true form on the ground that the will from which it proceeds is an *essence*-willing, a willing of the self according to its essential determinateness, ethical action acquires its *norm* in the *human being*, its *law* in the being's own law of activity, and its task becomes to express the total actual personality. Herewith there is once more a pointing back to *the opposition to the positively religious*. This opposition shows itself here partly as an opposition between the being's indwelling law and the supranatural, arbitrarily determined law of action, partly as an opposition between an ethical life which comprehends the total, real existence and a life which, as obeying the supranatural demand, flees away from the natural, relates itself negatively to the natural through asceticism, and expresses the spirit-side of the being in an abstractly spiritualistic way.

The result of the developments given in the foregoing we sum up in the following propositions:

1. True cognition, which is chosen in the choice between *knowledge* and *faith*, becomes the condition of the clearly conscious willing of the ethical, and of the ethical's concrete unfolding into a wholeness which comprehends the life of the actual personality.
 2. The personal life can be clarified through by true principle-determined cognition, and this cognition can, as it advances in concretion, win such a punctuality that the concrete ethical action can find in it its *ratio sufficiens*.
 3. The true unity of theory and practice, of the "theoretical" and the "practical" consciousness, is present in this relation, in which the subject's consciousness of its action and of its "grounds of will" is in harmony with its theoretical cognition of its essence and of the essence's demand; — and it is present *only* in this.
 4. In virtue of this relation between cognition and ethical action, since no splitting into incommensurable forms takes place within cognition, all that is truly ethical must be a rational ethical, just as all true ethics is a rational ethics. An antirational ethical is a self-contradiction, an antirational ethics an absurdity.
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II.

On the Presence of the Essential Marks of the Religious in its True Sense in True Cognition and True Action, and on their Relation of Unity to the Former.

1. The Essence of the Religious.

The expression for the religious relation which was used in the “preliminary determinations of concepts” in “Problemet om Tro og Viden” to designate that relation according to its ideal determinateness becomes here our starting point, and through the analysis of it we shall be able to reach the more concrete unfolding of the concept of the religious.

We there determined the religious relation as “*the absolute relation*^{*)} *to the Absolute*” — by an expression, therefore, which not merely in form approaches S. Kierkegaard’s usual designation of the stage of a religiousness not yet Christian, which he characterises as “the absolute direction towards the absolute τέλος”, but which has already been used by him where he sets the religious absolute relation beside the relative relations, which with him comprehend the ethical relations as well, and in which that absolute relation is not to exhaust itself or become concrete. While we thus appropriate his designation of the concept, it will nevertheless appear through the developments that follow how in our conception this designation acquires another significance than it had with Kierkegaard —

^{*)}If it should seem to “inverted” dialecticians contradictory to speak of an *absolute relation*, because relation expresses *relativity*, we need presumably only recall the Absolute’s relation to itself, and spirit’s infinity-relation to itself in the concretion of self-consciousness.

already where he speaks of the pre-Christian religious stage, and still more determinately where he speaks of the paradoxically religious.

If we analyse the determination of the religious relation as the absolute relation to the Absolute, then the analysis leads us to the following consequences, through which the concept acquires its more concrete determinateness.

a) *With respect to the Absolute*, which is the object of the relation, the fundamental determination encloses the following:

α) The “Absolute” which is the object of the religious relation can be an absolute *for us* only when it is *our* Absolute, i.e. when it stands in a relation of *essential unity* to us. In an opposition of essence there would lie immediately a determination irreconcilable with absoluteness. Against this unity of essence the ethical “absolute distinction” between God and guilty man, so strongly accentuated by Kierkegaard, does not tell; for the determination of guilt lies, as will be more closely developed under III, within the relation of immanence, and therefore makes no definitive breach in the unity of essence.

In the positive religion’s conception of the relation between God and man there is a doubleness present. On the one side likeness is accentuated, out of the immediate religious need: man is posited as created in God’s image; but on the other side the reflection determined by the form of representation leads to accentuating the opposition between the transcendent God and man, and this opposition fixes itself as an unabolishable one (cf. Section III, on reconciliation).

β) The object of the religious relation can be the Absolute for us only when it is *the in truth infinite*. Only the in truth infinite can be absolutely willed, absolutely sought through the need of the *whole* human being; and only what we will absolutely, absolutely strive towards, is for us an absolute. A willing of something finitely determinate is a finite willing, and the relation to it a finite, relative relation. This determination — that the Absolute must be the in truth infinite — is inseparable from the other, that it must stand in a relation of essential unity to us. For it can be the in truth infinite only when it is not separated from us by the barrier of a represented, and therefore finitely determined, transcendence.

Only these more formal determinations of the Absolute are necessary in the present connection; the more concrete determinations of the concept will be given under III, Chapter 1.

b) *With respect to the subject of the relation: man*, it follows from the determination “the absolute relation” that the subject must be present in the relation according to its essence’s *inner infinity*, that is to say, according to its *whole* essential determinateness, according to

the totality of its *universal* essence. The religious relation cannot, therefore, be a relation which relates itself to a single side of the human spirit or to a single fundamental function, even if this were thought to enclose the others within itself as moments — whereby the others would enter the relation precisely only *in the determinateness* they could have as moments; but it must be a relation into which the fundamental functions of the human spirit, as totalised within themselves, enter equally. Just as it therefore becomes a one-sidedness in the *Hegelian* philosophy of religion that it apprehends the religious relation exclusively as a relation of *cognition*, so it becomes just as fully a one-sidedness to determine it as a mere relation of *will*, or to designate it as what has been called, with a somewhat unclear expression, a relation of *life*, in *opposition* to a relation of cognition. The religious relation is a *life-relation in the sense* of a relation which comprehends *the whole of human life*; but human life, the life of spirit, is the life of cognition just as much as of will and of feeling; it is therefore apprehended in a one-sided and imperfect manner when it is apprehended only as opposed to cognition. But since the relation comprehends the totality of human life, the relation of will acquires on the other side a just as decisive and primitive significance, and it can step into the foreground where reconciliation is *sought*. The will in the relation to the Absolute is, when the relation is in truth, the religiously determined, *ethical* will, which actively transforms existence through the relation. Through this will the relation becomes a relation of *conscience*. That the relation is a *relation of personality* points back equally to cognition and to will^{*)}: what is a fundamental expression of the being is at the same time a fundamental expression of the personality; otherwise the determination of personality would stand in a merely contingent relation to the being, which is immediately self-contradictory.

That towards which spirit infinitely strives through the absolute relation so apprehended is *reconciliation*, and the religious life becomes a life for spirit's reconciliation *within itself and with its ground of essence*. This is as yet more a *metaphysical* determination of the religious relation, and it is reached already through the concept of spirit as that which according to its essence is infinite, and which, in order to find rest in itself, strives to realise this infinity within itself, but first realises it through the absolute relation to the in truth infinite, to its own and to existence's ground of essence. The specifically ethical-religious determination of the relation — the determination of reconciliation as reconciliation of *guilt* — will be developed only later.

Since the equal entry of the *whole* human spirit into the religious relation is thus accentuated, the divergent conceptions are to be touched upon which emphasise the

^{*)}Cf. the preceding Section.

one-sidedly limited determination of a *life-relation*. We may here take account partly of *Grundtvig*, partly of *Martensen*.

With the *former* an emphasis is laid on the relation of *life* in the sense of a relation of *immediacy*, which is so apprehended that the immediacy acquires the aesthetic character of sensible presence and comes to enclose within itself the moment of the magical. In the conception of the working of the “living Word”, of the power of the sacrament, spirit’s relation of freedom to spirit here gives room for a magical working; and while the religious consciousness, which by a postulate cuts reflection off at a determinate point, at the symbol, seeks rest in an unshakable, immovable objectivity, it exchanges the in truth religious relation for an aesthetic, poetic relation, in which the personality has not itself made the movement of infinity through true inwardisation, in which it does not know infinite resignation, but relates itself to the divine without knowing the seriousness of the relation, without remembering that the possibility of doubt becomes at every moment that which must be overcome if the relation is to be in truth, and that the anxiety of uncertainty becomes the ground upon which the victorious certainty of the relation of faith is to rest. Since, with a half-conscious shyness of thought, there is unclear talk of a relation of life into which the life of thought is not taken up, it is overlooked at this standpoint that a relation through cognition, through thought — precisely because cognition is the being’s expression, because it is the form of realisation for the relation of essence — becomes in the true sense a relation of life, and that it leads to *that* immediate unity which can be thought in the domain of the life of spirit.

With *Martensen* there comes forward an endeavour to bring the *whole* of human life into the religious relation: *faith* is determined as *a unity of religious feeling, cognition and will*. But in virtue of the subordinate and governed position which he lets cognition occupy in relation to faith, and in virtue of the conception he asserts of the *will* as “the concluding moment in religious consciousness”, this endeavour is not realised, and the relation of cognition is pressed back. Since the religious God-relation is separated from the speculative and the aesthetic, which are determined as relations “at second hand”, while the religious becomes an *existential relation*, a “consciousness of the God-relation which is one with the personal living and being in this relation”, then in this form of separation what is essential in the relation of cognition is pushed aside; the one-sided distinction between the impersonal and the personal is asserted also for that true, concrete cognition in which the self seeks a satisfaction for its deepest need, grounded in the essence of its personality. And this one-sided pressing back of the moment of cognition betrays itself also in the closer developments, in which the religious relation is

characterised as a *holy* relation, a relation of *conscience*; for through these determinations it is to be expressed that the relation of religion is a relation to the “*personal*” God, in *that* conception of the concept which raises it above the “logical” and makes the *will* the organ of the God-relation.

c) With respect to the *relative* relations it follows from the determination of the religious relation as the *absolute* one that this relation cannot fall outside them, but must comprehend them, penetrate them and make them absolute through their unity with it. In this unity — a unity conditioned by the ethical becoming something all-comprehending — the relative relations must acquire a higher significance, so that they can become adequate expressions of the religious, which has its concrete unfolding in them.

This determination receives its sharper elucidation by a comparison with S. Kierkegaard's conception of the relation between the absolute religious τέλος and the relative ones. As he seeks the expression for that form of religiousness which is not yet that of the paradoxically religious, the *first* expression of religious existence becomes for him *the absolute direction (respect) towards the absolute τέλος, expressed in action in the transformation of existence*. In the relation to the absolute τέλος *all* the moments of finitude are to be once and for all reduced, in action, to what must be given up in relation to eternal blessedness; only on condition of this exceptionless surrender is the existing individual in actuality to relate himself to the absolute τέλος, to will it absolutely. As the absolute τέλος for the willing individual who wills to strive absolutely, it is to be so abstract that, aesthetically regarded, it is the poorest representation; the willing individual is not even to will to know anything of this τέλος beyond that it exists; for as soon as he comes to know something of it, he is already to begin to be delayed in his course. The absolute τέλος is then not to be possessed at rest in existence; the whole time, the whole of existence, becomes the time of expectation. Mediation is to have no place here, because the existing individual is prevented from gaining such a footing outside existence that from it he could mediate what moreover, by being in becoming, withdraws itself from completedness. In relation to the absolute τέλος, that mediation takes place is to mean precisely that the absolute τέλος is reduced to a relative τέλος. It is not to be true that the absolute τέλος becomes concrete in the relative; for resignation's absolute distinction is at every moment to secure it against all fraternising. The absolute relation is to be able to demand the renunciation of *all* the relative ones. But for that very reason the one who relates himself to the absolute τέλος is nevertheless to be very well able to be in the relative ones; it will be precisely in renouncing that the absolute relation is practised: the relation which rests on the absolute distinction, the relation to that which is won

only by absolutely venturing all^{*)}.

In the first determination of the religious relation thus more closely developed, there are already indicated in Kierkegaard the consequences which come forward decisively where at last, within Christianity, the demand of the religious is raised so high that it consumingly burns up all finitude and with it all those ethical relations which, seen from this height, come under the determination of finitude. The religious relation here acquires the utmost abstraction: it can become the power which with the force of infinity draws the existing individual out of finitude and constantly gives him the direction towards the eternal; but it cannot win shape in the existing individual, cannot form his concrete actuality; for, as I have shown in another place^{**)}, it becomes only a *demand* that the individual should be able at one and the same time to relate himself absolutely to the absolute τέλος and relatively to the relative ones, in which the former is not to become concrete. But by this abstraction, which unavoidably attaches itself to the religious relation, that relation acquires precisely the character of *relativity* and loses the possibility of expressing the highest energy of the undivided human being; and in the finite which it is to be able to demand be given up there is also that which, as something essential, is something that cannot be given up: the ethical relations as a totality. A corrective against that conception lies already in this, that with Kierkegaard the fundamental ethical relation comes into being only as a relation of will to *the eternal*, and that the determination of the eternal in the domain of the ethical is not to be distinguished from the determination of it at that stage of the religious which we have characterised. If this is held fast, then the ethical cannot be apprehended as a stage of transition in the sense that there could be an ethical life which was not yet religious; rather the ethical becomes ethical only by being from the first religious. And precisely for that reason the religious stands in such a relation to the ethical that it must always find its expression in the ethical — so that there cannot be thought a surrender, warranted by the religious, of the totality of the ethical, of all the ethical relations, but the renunciation of an ethical relation must always be in virtue of a higher and more comprehensive ethical, and religious renunciation must therefore always be borne by ethical action.

d) The first, essential determination of the religious relation was therefore that it was an *absolute, infinite* relation. And in the concept of the human spirit, in its essential determination, lies the *necessity* of such a relation for the human spirit. Infinity is its essence, its true element of life; only in a relation of infinity can it therefore come to rest, and so that it stands in an absolute relation — i.e. in a relation of infinity — not merely

^{*)}Kierkegaard: Afsluttende Efterskrift, pp. 295 ff.

^{**)}Problemet om Tro og Viden, p. 221.

according to a single one of its fundamental functions but according to their totality. Even when the content of spirit is converted into the form of *feeling*, the relation's absoluteness can be preserved, since feeling, in totalised unity with cognition and will, becomes that intensive form of immediacy of spirit whose content has the infinite richness of unfolded possibility, and which at every moment can become mobile and be clarified through in cognition and will.

e) That first determination of the religious relation, as the absolute relation to the Absolute, now acquires a *more concrete* form in that the limitation of *existence*, the determinateness by *finitude*, of the human being that enters the religious relation is accentuated. At this point, however, only the general determinations to which this standpoint leads are to be indicated; the closer consequences — namely with respect to the significance of the temporal relation for the ethical-religious life, for guilt and its abolition — will be shown in the last Section.

The new determinations that come in, and that express that the absolute relation to the Absolute is the absolute relation to the Absolute of a human spirit which is *according to its essence infinite* but which *exists in determinateness by finitude*, are the determinations of *faith* and of *self-surrender*. Of these, when they are distinguished, the first points rather to cognition, the second to will — but so that faith's cognition must according to its truth be determined as being in inner, harmonious unity with the will, and self-surrender's will as standing in the same relation of unity to cognition.

f) The determination of *faith* comes forward in that the finite consciousness is, out of its determinateness by finitude, to grasp the infinite and eternal in the form of certainty and to hold it fast as that which penetrates and determines finitude. Faith is a postulate of cognition, an inference incommensurable with its premisses: in the relation to the eternally present it leaps over the intermediate links of grounding cognition and grasps the eternally present as this present; it transforms the uncertainty of what is to come into the certainty of something present. In this relation faith shows itself to stand at one and the same time in relation to the being's determinateness by finitude and to its determinateness by infinity. Faith is only as that certainty which is born of uncertainty, which as it were unwinds itself out of uncertainty; and through the uncertainty which at every moment is to be conquered, finitude betrays itself. But that certainty can be won through uncertainty, that uncertainty *can* be conquered, shows the infinity of spirit. That which warrants faith's postulate, that which fills out the distance between its premisses and its conclusion, is *the essential determination of the human spirit*, which with the necessity of the *a priori* points to *the Absolute* as that without which consciousness

would lose its hold upon itself. It is the being's infinity which, through the enclosure of finitude, compels consciousness to acknowledge the infinite and eternal^{*)}. And through the infinity of the *being* there works the infinity of the *principle*, by which the being has its being. That postulate of faith has therefore at once a human and a divine origin; it is an expression of the unity of the working of the human and of the divine spirit.

As such a postulate of cognition faith is at work in that, in the ethical choice, man's living is determined by the infinite and eternal; and as such it is at work in that the infinity of life is held fast in the particular action which fills out human life and which, as *ethical*, confirms that primitive choice's constituting of the character of the life of spirit.

In the ethical choice and in the ethical action which confirms the choice there reveals itself the *true form of the unity of cognition and will* in the relation of faith. The choice, and the action which rests upon the choice, is at one and the same time the expression of that energy of cognition with which cognition breaks through the finitude that veils infinity and with the power of its own essence grasps infinity, and the expression of the will's resolution. The will, which through cognition is clear about itself, demands as the goal in which it, as essence-willing, can come to rest, the infinite, which is the condition of the infinity of essence; it demands the infinite in order to be able to be itself^{*)}. And just as the will demands the Absolute in order to rest in it, so also does feeling first find rest in it; and feeling preserves the Absolute's absoluteness in that at every moment of its intensive concentration it as it were conceals within itself the memory of cognition and the tension towards will.

g) The determination of *self-surrender* comes forward in that the particular finite will is to break through the determinateness by finitude in which it immediately has its life, in order to will infinitely, and in this willing — which is a willing of the true infinity of its own essence — to enter into the absolute relation, to set itself in unity with the in truth infinite, to let itself be determined by the in truth infinite as a member of that totality, that community of spirit, which the infinite governs.

Self-surrender is first the self-surrender of *the choice*, the choosing will's decisive surrender in principle of the determinateness by finitude in order to be able to grasp

^{*)}Immediately there lies in this as yet only such an acknowledgement as can be united with an averted disposition, as when it is said of the demons in the New Testament that they believe in God and tremble. But when the infinite is to be acknowledged as the in truth infinite, then this acknowledgement is conditioned by a faith which acknowledges the infinite and eternal in its validity as the ideal of human life, by a faith which is in unity with self-surrender. In that relation in which faith stands beside an averted disposition, the divine becomes, through the *opposition* to the self's abstract infinity, only an abstract infinite, in reality therefore only a finite, with the form of negative infinity. The rest of infinity which spirit seeks, because infinity is its essential determination, is therefore found only where faith and self-surrender are in unity, i.e. where faith is according to the completeness of its essence.

^{*)}The will's possible resistance to the divine will be elucidated under Section III.

infinity. But the moment of the constituting choice is to be unfolded so as to comprehend a *whole* life, in whose particular actions the choice, formed into an abiding resolution, repeats itself, through the confirmation of the will's first surrender of the finite content of will and of its own selfishness. In the choice and in the repetition of the choice, self-surrender acquires on the one side the form of resignation, of dying away from immediacy (S. Kierkegaard), of inwardisation, of "self-annihilation" in the sense of the abolition of the selfish; and on the other side — since the goal is a regaining by the self of itself according to its determinateness by eternity and in concrete actuality — the form of a self-assertion according to the self's truth. But since such a regaining, such a self-asserting, is possible only through the unity with the divine, which is the principle of the being, self-surrender acquires the form of a surrender to the working of the divine («*Deum pati*») — a surrender which is not merely the purification of the finite will but, as its infinitising, the expression of its highest energy: it becomes a suffering which is one with the highest acting^{*)}.

Its *definitive* determination self-surrender acquires in that the subject which surrenders itself to the divine determines its own life in the determinateness by finitude as *guilt* — in that self-surrender therefore becomes one with consciousness's repentant acknowledgement of guilt, and with its striving after that guilt's reconciliation in God through a divine working. This determination is here only touched upon; its closer development will be given under Section III, as will the demonstration of its relation to the determinations of the Christian.

In self-surrender, in which the will's working comes forward primitively, this will is, as emerges from the earlier developments, conditioned by and in unity with cognition. And just as fully as self-surrender beneath the infinite must be determined as the will's goal, so must it also be determined as cognition's and as feeling's; for when the cognising spirit, through the surrender of its finitude, finds rest in self-surrender to the infinite, spirit as feeling finds rest in that self-surrender which is the self-surrender of the feeling of absolute dependence.

h) In the foregoing it has already been indicated how the moment of faith and the moment of self-surrender in the religious relation stand in the closest connection with one another. Their concepts presuppose one another, and in their full and true

^{*)}With S. Kierkegaard religious suffering and self-annihilation are set in opposition to the ethical self-assertion in which the existing individual, by "repenting through", is to find himself again. This opposition hangs together with the conception of the ethical stage as a stage of transition. If the ethical is apprehended in that original unity with the religious which has been shown above, then already the ethical self-assertion becomes a self-assertion through unity with the self's absolute principle, and the opposition between the religious and the ethical relation is abolished.

significance they cannot be thought without one another. Faith presupposes, as was shown (p. 39 note), self-surrender in order to be able to be faith in the in truth infinite; it presupposes self-surrender in order to be able to grow its own growth; and it bears self-surrender within itself, since as a grasping and a holding fast of the eternal — which in faith's certainty is lifted out of the uncertainty of doubt — it is a self-giving of spirit to the eternal truth in which human life as a whole finds rest. And just as faith presupposes self-surrender, so self-surrender presupposes faith, precisely in order to be able to be self-surrender to the *true* divine, i.e. in order in truth to be able to be self-surrender; and that action of self-surrender by which the self wins its life through the surrender of its life's selfishness is such that life can be regained in its truth and eternity only through faith in the eternal, to which life can thus be surrendered.

i) If we sum up the given determinations of the essence of the religious relation, then religion, according to its ideal significance, becomes the absolute relation to the Absolute as the true infinite standing in a relation of essential unity with us. It becomes a relation which, as grounded in the human being itself, comprehends the whole of human life, all the fundamental activities of spirit. It becomes — since man is seen as a unity of infinity and finitude — a relation of faith and of self-surrender; a relation through which the human spirit, entangled in finitude and bound in guilt, finds reconciliation within itself and with its own origin.

The relation between religion in the sense indicated and the *positive* religions is indicated in its main features in the “preliminary determinations of concepts” in the earlier work; it will emerge more determinately from the developments that follow.

The relation of the conception developed above to S. *Kierkegaard's* determinations of the essence of the religious has already been partly touched upon. It shows itself at first glance that this conception has essential points of connection in his determination of that stage of religiousness which is not yet that of the paradoxically religious; but an incisive difference came forward in the difference of conception of the religious's relation to the ethical, of the absolute relation's relation to the relative ones. From *Kierkegaard's* determination of the religious as the *paradoxically* religious that conception must of course diverge still more decisively. What sharpens the difference here is the opposition between immanence and abstract transcendence; between the view of the human *being's* imperturbability and man's *essence*-transformation through sin; between the maintaining of cognition in the religious relation and its annihilation through the paradox, the absolutely incomprehensible; between the acknowledgement of the real's essential validity

and essential unity with the ideal in existence's principle, in existence's wholeness and in the human being^{*)}, and Christianity's absolutely spiritualistic conception, which with Kierkegaard becomes manifest in the negative consequences with which he concludes. With these oppositions an essential difference in the conception of reconciliation will also show itself to stand in connection.

2. Cognition's Relation to the Religious according to its Ideal Determinateness.

In order that cognition's relation to the religious, in the ideal sense of this concept, may show itself as a relation of unity, it must be established that cognition, by its relation to the human being and by the form in which it expresses the being, can become the medium for a relation of infinity, an absolute relation; that it can have absolute significance for the human spirit; and that it encloses within itself that moment of faith and of self-surrender which showed itself to be an essential mark of the religious.

a) The condition for cognition's being able to become, for the human spirit, the form of an absolute relation is that it can preserve the object's true infinity within the relation. That it must be able to preserve the determinateness by infinity lies already, so far, in cognition's form, in that this form is determined by the universal; and this universal — whose being as universal for human consciousness is conditioned by the being's inner infinity — stands in essential connection with the infinite. But in order that through this form of cognition the infinite may be preserved as the in truth infinite, cognition's form of universality must be in concrete unity with the other fundamental forms of the concept. In order that it may be this, it is presupposed that cognition in the relation to the Absolute does not stand in abstract opposition to what is just as fully a fundamental function of spirit, and that it does not become a one-sided form of spirit's activity, isolated from what supplements and totalises it. As such it would, for example, unavoidably have to be apprehended if it were separated from the will by an absolute heterogeneity of principle; for in this separation the will would appropriate the determination of singularity as its fundamental form and let cognition's form of universality become that of abstract universality, while the will's form of singularity, in its separation from the universal, would become precisely only the form of immediate natural singularity. In this abstract opposition neither of the functions of spirit would be apprehended according to its truth, i.e. as an expression of the undivided, total human

^{*)}Cf. the following Section (III).

spirit, and neither of them would come in truth to relate itself to the infinite, because the infinite in its true infinity could not be for either of them.

With respect to the relation between the formal determinatenesses of the primitive functions of spirit, what is needful has been developed in the previous Section and in the earlier work, pp. 134 ff. It has been shown in what relation cognition's determinateness by universality stands to the particular and the concrete, and how the will's determinateness by singularity — precisely because the *will's* singularity is "singularity of spirit" — unfolds the determinateness of the universal out of itself. Of what nature the will's determinateness by singularity is shows itself already through the fact that the will has its limit in the organism against the singularity and immediacy of nature-determined reality; and the will's psychological relation to that determinateness by drive out of which it unfolds itself in the course of the development of the life of spirit, and into which it is unconsciously converted as acting upon the self's natural side, its organism — as for example when an act of will calls forth a momentary or a mechanically continued movement — points to a limit of the will as will, by which its form of singularity is determined. If, however, in order to maintain the absolute heterogeneity, one were to let the will's universal set itself up as something absolutely heterogeneous from cognition's universal, then such a doubling of the universal into two absolutely heterogeneous kinds of universal, yet designated by the same common determination, would immediately enclose a self-contradiction, an absurdity. From what has been developed in the foregoing it therefore emerges that for that cognition which, as an essential expression of the human spirit undivided within itself, cannot be held fast in abstract separation from what is just as fully a primitive expression of spirit, and which is therefore not one-sidedly determined by a single fundamental form of the concept — for such cognition the Absolute can be an object according to its truth, as the in truth infinite; and its infinity can be preserved under the relative abstraction. It can therefore be present for cognition in the form in which it is the object of religion according to religion's ideal significance, in which it is the object of faith as that which is demanded by the human spirit, as that goal of spirit in which the being's claim finds satisfaction, in which spirit first finds rest.

b) That cognition can have *absolute* significance for the human spirit — that significance, therefore, which it must be able to have in order to be able to express the religious relation — shows itself first through this, that cognition, in virtue of its relation to the human being, must be *an end in and for itself*. It becomes an end in that it is a realisation of a fundamental determination in the human spirit, and more closely, of the determination which is according to the concept principal in spirit; but this means: it

is an end as the being's realisation in one of the being's fundamental forms. But since it is a form for the realisation of the universal being, it is the form for the individual spirit's expansion so as ideally to take up the whole of infinite existence; it is the energy which ideally binds the individual spirit together with this whole of existence. Thereby cognition's absolute significance shows itself from a new standpoint; for in realising spirit's determinateness by universality, and in ideally binding spirit together with the whole of existence, it binds spirit together with existence's principle, the Absolute, which as such is cognition's principle and moving power, that upon whose cognition all true cognition rests. Cognition therefore acquires, from this standpoint, absolute significance because it realises that relation of spirit to the Absolute which is laid down in the human being; and since this realising of the human being's deepest relation is seen as being only through the working of the indwelling Absolute, cognition's absolute significance shows itself once more in a new light, which makes it still clearer how spirit can relate itself religiously in cognition and to cognition.

From the standpoints emphasised, cognition has as yet been directly regarded only according to its significance in the *theoretical* respect, through which it already shows itself as a self-valid end for that being which in cognition realises itself according to a fundamental determination within itself, and which precisely only in relating itself to cognition as an end can be present in cognition with spirit's whole power, with that love of cognition by which alone cognition becomes productive and creative, animated by the idea. But since now the human being — which in cognition realises itself and realises its ideal unity with existence and with existence's principle — as a being which comprehends a *totality* of functions, enters as an active *member* into a whole of existence and becomes conscious of itself as such, cognition's absolute significance is also to be seen from the standpoint of *action*. How it is to be apprehended from this standpoint emerges from what was developed in the previous Section. Only through cognition does that action become possible in which the individual works according to its absolute determination, which is the being's realisation through the will's freedom. Cognition showed itself to become the presupposition of such an action, partly by its clarifying, liberating, purifying influence upon the will, partly as determining the content of the true will. From this standpoint — where cognition shows itself as a function within an organic wholeness of life, while it works as a condition, as a means, for the ethical — it is at the same time to be seen as an ethical *end*, and as working towards its own realisation in working towards the realisation of that unity of life in which it has its truth. And since cognition exercises upon the other activities of spirit, upon the life of feeling and

the life of imagination, the same purifying and clarifying influence which it exercised upon the will, it shows itself in its relation to them too in its significance as realising the inner unity and harmony of the total human being; and this standpoint thus leads back to the first, from which cognition was seen as a realisation of the human being.

c) That there is in cognition a moment of *faith* — not in the Jacobian sense of an immediate certainty of being, but in a sense in which the fundamental determination of the religious relation of faith is preserved — shows itself at *every* stage of cognition's development. This moment of faith is covertly present in the lower forms of cognition everywhere where a universal is asserted on the ground of the particular that is incongruent with it. Where a universal law asserts in virtue of the incompletely given particular, where the incomplete premiss of induction is therefore given validity as a complete one, there the universal is brought forward in that the empirical is supplemented in virtue of something a priori, that is, in virtue of a claim of the *being* to unity and lawfulness. And what thus already shows itself where in a lower sphere a *relative universal* comes forward, shows itself still more plainly where the *universal in the highest sense*, the *total existence's* universal principle, is grasped by cognition out of incomplete presuppositions. For since one goes beyond experience's unavoidable incompleteness, the unity-principle of an existence not exhausted by experience is grasped, not as that whose certainty experience secures, but as that which is reached by a necessary postulate out of the individual consciousness, which without it would lose its hold upon itself, become uncertain of its own unity, be confused within itself. This postulate of the principle — which as existence's principle is the human spirit's principle of life — comes forward also in that cognition which is the presupposition of the primitive ethical choice by which the self constitutes itself as an ethical self; and just as, therefore, the cognition upon which this choice rests encloses the moment of faith, so this moment is present also in that cognition for which the incomplete premisses of the particular ethical action acquire validity as complete ones, as an action's *ratio sufficiens*.

In this — that it is a demand proceeding with necessity from the being's own source, and a demand which encloses the immediate acknowledgement of what is demanded — the faith which cognition encloses agrees with the faith which has been determined as the distinguishing mark of the religious. But the faith which is present in cognition itself must have the character of the *rational*. In demanding the Absolute, its demand rests upon the thinking human being's consciousness of itself; it does not come into conflict with that consciousness, but confirms it. Faith as rational faith becomes a faith in that which is higher than the individual, in that it is the principle which grounds the

individual spirits and the whole of existence; but which, in being determined as higher, is at the same time determined as of the same essence, precisely because it is the *principle* of the human being and of existence. And since the being from which the religious demand of faith proceeds is an indivisible unity, there lies in this incontrovertibly that this demand, in order in truth to express the being's claim, cannot stand in conflict with any true expression of the being, and therefore not with thought, with cognition. Faith in the sense of the in truth religious can therefore not be a faith which stands in principle opposed to knowledge; by this disharmony in principle it would show itself not to have its source in the essential. This faith must, in virtue of the being's unity, stand in harmony in principle with knowledge; but in virtue of the human spirit's determinateness by finitude, faith must, as *anticipating the result*, acquire an *abiding* significance as something necessary for the human spirit. It is the form of the indispensable anticipation of certainty; it is the demand grounded in essence, which has the being's own necessity; it is therefore not like an uncertain knowledge, but like an inference without premisses which nevertheless has incontrovertible certainty, because the premisses are hidden in the being itself. But precisely therefore, precisely because faith draws its certainty from this source in the being, it cannot come into conflict with what springs clearly and transparently from the same source. Where, therefore, that which is posited as a determination of faith incontrovertibly conflicts with knowledge — and it does so when it conflicts not merely with this or that determination of knowledge, but with what makes knowledge knowledge, with *knowledge's principle, the principle of grounding and of necessity* — there it cannot have truth. But in such conflict with knowledge's very principle stands, for example, faith in the miracle, when the miracle is taken in the sense in which positive religion takes it, not in the effaced and falsified sense in which it is taken by a half-theological inverted speculation.

When "faith" at the stage of the positive religions appears with a claim to unconditional validity, then it must support this claim either upon its divine origin or upon its springing from what is innermost and most essential in the human spirit. If it supports the claim upon its springing from the transcendent divine — and only when the divine is so apprehended do the two standpoints fall outside one another — then faith with its supernatural origin and its supernatural content must be posited as raised above all knowledge and at the same time as standing in opposition to all knowledge. But since knowledge is seen as an expression of that human nature which has its springing from God, there arises not merely a discord between the divine's opposed forms of revelation, in faith and in thought, but there arises an unabridged and unabridishable discord in the

human spirit, which is to deny one expression of essence in order to acknowledge an effect proceeding from the same source from which the human being itself has sprung. If then, in order to maintain the necessity of acknowledging “revelation”, reference is made to the demand of personality, to a norm within personality, then the last of the standpoints indicated above has hereby been put in the place of the first. But when faith then rests upon the being’s inescapable claim, then what was said above holds again: that this being’s unity must preserve the harmony between the expressions of the being; and a harmony is then required between faith’s content and what is essential in knowledge. As surely as there have been, and constantly can be, false forms of the positively religious — forms of doctrine and cultus which most deeply offend the moral consciousness^{*)} — and as surely as conscience can be entangled and unclear in the individual, so surely is a norm required which cannot be sought in something absolutely heterogeneous with knowledge, but must be sought in knowledge’s negative corrective, in that veto of knowledge which must retain its validity; because, when knowledge is denied, that regulative is lost by which a distinction can be drawn between the true faith grounded in the being and that which is only an expression of finite craving and desire, of something unessential and particular in human nature. Knowledge’s relation to the proposition of faith may be such that knowledge must halt at a *non liquet*; but knowledge’s relation can never become such that it must approve what indisputably contradicts its *principle*, annihilates it as knowledge.

d) In cognition, as cognition is according to its truth, there is finally present that moment of *self-surrender* which characterised the in truth religious relation. In all true cognition there is a purification of thought, a surrender of individual entanglement, opinion and prejudice — in one word, of thought’s selfishness; there is in it a self-surrender to truth’s absolute power. And this self-surrender, which is present in all true cognition, shows itself most clearly in that relation in which cognition, in virtue of the being’s demand of faith, surrenders itself to the infinite that satisfies the being’s need. In this surrender, which is conditioned by an inner necessity of the being, cognition is in unity with the will; and in being itself infinitised in the surrender, cognition clarifies that will whose choice is determined by the same power of the being.

e) The result of what has been developed is therefore that cognition in its truth stands in an essential relation of unity to the religious in its ideal determinateness, to the religious faith which is the expression of the human being’s infinite demand. Under the conditions of finitude of the human spirit there is indeed as it were an interval between

^{*)}It is here sufficient to recall the Near Eastern religions.

faith and knowledge, but an interval which must be able to be traversed by knowledge. A discord in principle, unabolishable, becomes an impossibility, because that faith which abolished knowledge's essential determination would precisely thereby show itself as not according with faith's own essence. Under the changing of its historical forms faith has a development, and its essential connection with knowledge shows itself in this, that this development of faith is not torn loose from that of knowledge, is not without the liberating knowledge.

3. The Relation of the Will and of Action to the Religious according to its Ideal Determinateness.

In determining the relation of the will and of action to the religious, the same standpoints will have to be brought to bear as were emphasised in the foregoing with respect to cognition.

a) There is then first to be brought out that the possibility of an absolute relation to the Absolute through the will is present, in that the will, in its harmony with cognition and in its being clarified through by the universal, has the capacity to preserve its object's true infinity — a capacity which would have to be denied if one let an absolute heterogeneity separate the will from cognition, or if, on the ground of an unclear representation of the being's "defectiveness", an *abiding* irrational element in the will were postulated. The Absolute is present as absolute in the will's form as *the good*, and man's willing of the good is in unity with the cognition of it. As this willing of the Absolute as the good impresses itself in action, this action acquires — as will be more closely developed in what follows — the shape of a realisation of the good in the form of the human being, governed by the will's unconditional submission to the Absolute's demand; so that this realising, through the unconditional submission, becomes the expression of the realisation of essential unity with the divine (ὁμοιωθῆναι θεῷ), and therefore the form of an absolute relation of will to the Absolute.

b) The *absolute significance* of true willing and of true acting for the human spirit shows itself immediately, in that the will as *essence*-willing conditions the unfolding of the human being's endowment in real actuality, and constitutes the true relation to the Absolute. As shown above, this twofold standpoint comes together into an inseparable unity.

When, in the development of the ethical's coming into being in the individual, the expression was used that the self in the ethical choice chooses and wills *itself absolutely*,

there was a pointer to this: that such choosing is possible only through the self's standing in a *relation of essential unity to the Absolute*; for only in virtue of such a relation can it be chosen absolutely. That expression must be taken as the starting point, because, if we determined the object of the choice as the absolute idea of the good, the choice of this as that which is to be realised in *human* action would be identical with the choice of the *humanly good*, of the *ideally human*. In this the absolute idea is for man in *the determinateness of his essence*, and in being realised through the free will, actuality is given to the idea. Beyond the determination of the ideally human as the task of human action we cannot come. We can realise only that Absolute which is *our* absolute essence, actualise only that ideal which is *our* ideal. From the determination of the ethical task as the realisation of the idea of the good as such we are at once led back to the limit indicated, by the fact that what realises must be congruent with what is to be realised; the Absolute can then be *positively* realised by us only in so far as it expresses itself in the determinateness of our essence. But this limitation of the positive expression for the idea's realisation through the will does not exclude, but precisely presupposes, another negative form of realisation, in which the idea makes itself felt *as such*. If we see the human individual ordered as a member into a principle-determined organised totality, then it follows indeed from its determinateness as a single organic member that it can positively express the principle only through the active unfolding of the individuality's own essence; but in the form of negation (self-surrender) it expresses the whole as whole, the principle as principle, in virtue of the whole's and the principle's presence within it in the abstract form of possibility. Through that determination of the ethical choice and the ethical task which was our starting point there is therefore a pointer to the relation to the Absolute as that by which the self in its ideality can become an absolute task to itself, and which acquires presence in the ethically unfolded self; and the absolute significance of ethical willing and acting therefore shows itself from a twofold standpoint.

To the same result we are led when we start from the other expression for the ethical choice: that the self in that choice chooses *itself according to its essential determinateness*. For the choice of the self according to its essence is a choice of the being *according to its total concretion*, and therefore according to its determinateness *as an organic member in a totality of existence*. In cognising itself in this determinateness, the self is from the beginning in relation to that principle which is the governing principle of life of the total existence. The I's self-assertion in the ethical choice is only through the principle's working through the I, and in that the I asserts itself, but asserts itself in its being ordered into the totality, its self-assertion is only as self-surrender to the principle. And what

holds of the I's relation in the ethical choice holds of its relation in the particular ethical action, for which this choice forms the foundation. As the ethical wins concretion, and ethical willing forms itself as that willing of the being according to its completeness which has been clarified by true cognition, the relation is at every point posited to that totality into which the self as ethical freely orders itself, and to the totality's principle. The relation which was posited in the ethical choice, when the ethically a priori first acquired validity for the will, is preserved as this a priori wins fullness in the concrete action. The twofold standpoint for the ethical's absolute significance thus gathers itself once more into unity.

When the relation to the Absolute which is constituted in the ethical choice is posited as preserved everywhere in ethical action, this leads to an essential consequence — already drawn above from another standpoint — for the conception of the *particular* ethical relations. From the fact that in these relations in their singularity there is at every point a relation to the Absolute working through them, it follows that the particular ethical relations, which in their isolation would have to be determined as merely relative relations, become relations with absolute significance, expressions of the absolute relation. The absolute relation is seen as comprehending all the ethical relations, as indwelling in them, and as unfolding through them a concrete content and winning the shape of actuality. Thereby the particular ethical relations acquire a higher significance; and in apprehending them in this significance the subject relates itself religiously to the ethical, which now in its articulation acquires absolute validity, becomes an absolute end for the subject.

It is only another expression for the same thing when it was said that the ethical can never as a whole be given up for a religious τέλος which as an absolute should raise itself above everything ethical. It cannot, because the ethical is an expression of essence, because through its relation to the Absolute it has absolute significance, and because it stands in indissoluble connection with the religious. In the collision in actuality between the different forms of the ethical, the ethical from one sphere may give way to the ethical from another which comes forward with the right of the higher universal; but in resigning a single one of the ethical relations — which, as members in the ethical totality, are according to their essence absolute relations — the resignation of the particular relation is in virtue of the ethical totality, which in the resignation *integrates itself*. The resignation of the particular ethical relation is therefore in virtue of the ethical itself; there arises no absolute relation outside the ethical, but the Absolute becomes omnipresent within the ethical.

c) In the ethical thus apprehended — the expression of true, essential willing and acting — the moment of faith has already been shown to be present. It has been shown that it comes forward not merely in the ethical choice's first grasping of the Absolute, but everywhere in the choice's confirmation in repetition, in every ethical resolution in which the individual determines itself to action in spite of cognition's incompleteness and the uncertainty of realisation, of the outcome; and it comes forward likewise in that the individual, under the incomplete realisation of the ethical demand, acknowledges in the indwelling, through-working principle — with which it is in unity through love's self-surrender — that which ethically completes.

d) The moment of self-surrender in the ethical has already been touched upon, in that the negative form for the realisation of the absolute good was indicated, and in that it was shown that the self's assertion of itself, as an assertion of the self according to its essence's *complete* determinateness — according to which it is a moment in a whole governed by the principle — became one with a self-surrender of love and of resignation to that principle by which the self's essence is, and in which it first finds itself again according to the truth of its essence. This holds with respect to the first ethical choice and to each particular ethical action. Since now ethical self-assertion is self-assertion through self-surrender, *love* is the principle of the ethical; and since the self is seen in relation to the Absolute and to the spiritual wholeness of life into which it is ordered, love's object becomes the Absolute, the principle, and man *as man* (the neighbour). In the relation of love to man the relation of love to the Absolute is revealed: in the ethical-religious relation to humanity there is a relation to the Absolute, which is humanity's ground of life. In this love of the Absolute and of man *as man*, self-love is transfigured and man's innermost essence revealed. "Only that man is something who loves something, and what a man is shall be known by what he loves". (Feuerbach).

e) Thus the result with respect to the will's relation to the religious becomes the same as with respect to cognition's. The relation between the will in its truth — the essence-willing at work in ethical action — and the religious according to its ideal determinateness is a relation of unity, and must be so, because a fundamental function of the being cannot contradict what expresses the human being's deepest claim, its infinite demand.

4. The Reconciliation of the Human Spirit in the Ethical-Human Life Resting upon True Cognition.

When human life is unfolded in harmonious unity of true cognition and true action; when cognition in its truth bears within itself faith according to the ideal significance of that concept; when the ethical action, in which the human being according to its concretion finds its realisation, has as ethical action the true stamp of the religious; and when finally the human being through cognition and action stands in relation to an existence and to a principle of existence from which all dualistic dividing has been removed — then the conditions are present without which spirit cannot find rest and reconciliation. What proceeded immediately from the essence of the human spirit was a striving after the realisation of its inner infinity as a true infinity; and this realisation can take place only on the conditions that spirit's activities are not divided, that they do not follow heterogeneous laws, and that spirit in its relation to existence and to the principle is not hindered by the finitude-barrier of a dualism. But in the true cognition of the Absolute, of the totality of existence and of the self; in the true ethical willing, which equally accentuates the self's self-assertion and its ordering into the totality, its spirit-side and its nature-side; in the true religious relation, which as the absolute relation penetrates the relative ones and in them wins concretion — in these this concrete infinity is present; and since cognition, morality and religiousness are harmoniously bound together, the condition is brought about under which spirit's original striving can come to rest, under which spirit's reconciliation with itself in its actuality can take place — a reconciliation which must be lacking so long as spirit is divided by conflicting powers, so long as consciousness is split within itself, at every moment torn asunder by doubt about cognition's truth and about action's validity. Only through that harmonious realisation of all the powers of the life of spirit does human life also become in truth a *human* life according to the full significance of that concept; and the character of humanity reveals itself in the *universal* love of humanity, of the human *as* human.

III.

**The Central Ethical-Religious
Problems, Apprehended from the
Standpoint of Knowledge.**

Conclusion.

Errata: